

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Sir Keir Starmer said he has “full confidence” in **Wes Streeting**, despite reports that the health secretary will challenge him for leadership of the Labour Party as soon as Thursday. Mr Streeting met the beleaguered prime minister briefly on Wednesday. Speculation about the leadership crisis overshadowed a speech in Parliament by **King Charles III** outlining the government’s plans. Nearly 100 Labour MPs have demanded Sir Keir’s resignation.

Donald Trump arrived in Beijing for a summit [with Xi Jinping](#), **China’s** leader. Talks will focus on commerce. A group of chief executives, including Jensen Huang, boss of Nvidia, a chipmaker, have joined the trip. But security will also feature: Mr Trump said he will not ask Mr Xi for “any help with Iran”, but suggested the pair will discuss [arms sales to Taiwan](#), alarming America’s Asian allies.

Gunshots rang out after the **Philippines’** armed forces entered the country’s Senate, where a senator wanted by the International Criminal Court is hunkering down. **Ronald dela Rosa** is accused of overseeing the brutal anti-drug campaign of a former president, Rodrigo Duterte. On Monday Sara Duterte, the vice-president and

Mr Duterte's daughter, [was impeached](#), setting off a battle to determine who will lead the country.

France's unemployment rate rose unexpectedly to 8.1% in the first quarter of the year, its highest level since 2021. The figures represent a setback for president [Emmanuel Macron](#). Since taking office in 2017, he has pushed through numerous reforms to tackle the high unemployment rates that have plagued France's labour market for decades.

Samsung Electronics failed to agree on a pay deal with its biggest union, raising the risk of a strike that would disrupt production at the [South Korean](#) tech giant—and hurt the country's wider economy. Workers want the firm to remove caps on bonuses as it profits from voracious demand for artificial-intelligence memory chips. The union has threatened an 18-day walkout beginning on May 21st.

Alibaba reported a quarterly operating loss of 848m yuan (\$123m), its first since the pandemic. The shortfall highlights the difficulty the Chinese tech giant faces in monetising the billions of dollars it has invested in AI. It has committed \$56bn to the technology over three years, which weighed on profitability; its core profit plunged 84% year-on-year. Its share price fell by 3% following the announcement.

Sam Altman took the stand to reject allegations that he broke a vow to keep OpenAI a non-profit organisation. A [lawsuit](#) brought by **Elon Musk**, who founded the AI lab alongside Mr Altman over a decade ago, accuses him of trying to “steal a charity” by turning it into a commercial venture. Mr Altman said OpenAI's for-profit arm was a “creative way” to keep the lab going. The trial will continue on Wednesday.

700,000, the number of robotaxis expected to roam Chinese cities within five years, according to Goldman Sachs, a bank. [Read why](#)

China wants more robots, but not fewer workers.



Photograph: Reuters

The America-Iran stalemate

Donald Trump will arrive in Beijing on Wednesday with his war against Iran [stuck in a stalemate](#). Iran's latest proposal for a permanent ceasefire, delivered on Sunday, was promptly dismissed by the Americans: the president described it as "TOTALLY UNACCEPTABLE" on social media. The warring parties have been unable to agree on issues including the duration of a moratorium on Iran's uranium enrichment and what to do with the highly enriched uranium the country already holds.

Mr Trump insists time will work in his favour: "We have a blockade...we don't have to rush anything," he said on Tuesday. The problem is that Iranian officials take the same view. According to recently released data, soaring petrol prices helped push American annual inflation to 3.8% in April, its highest in nearly three years. Each side believes economic pain will force the other to make big concessions. At the same time, neither seems eager to resume fighting. A long deadlock looms.



Photograph: Reuters

Sir Keir Starmer clings on, for now

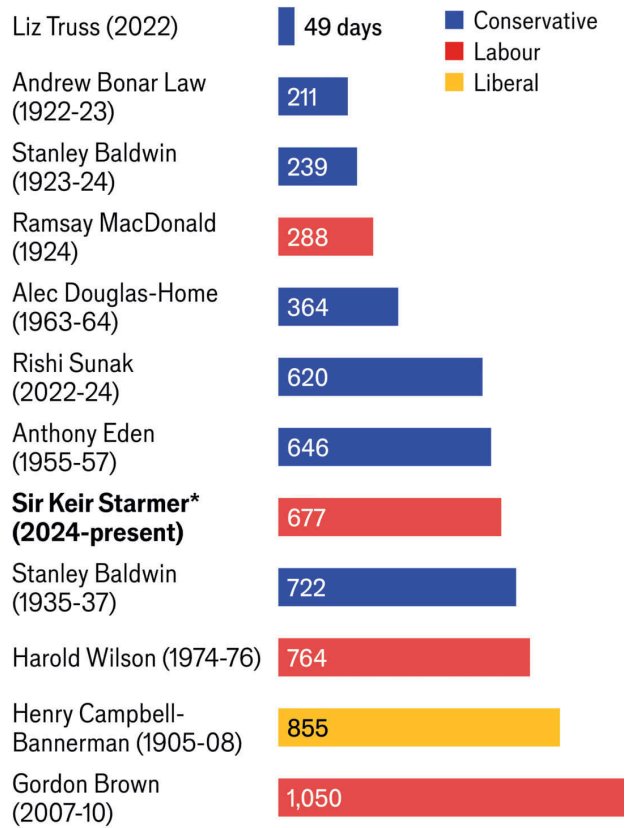
On Wednesday King Charles III is set to outline the British government's legislative plans in an address to Parliament. He won't mention the elephant in the chamber: the head of that government may soon have to quit, throwing the agenda into disarray.

Nearly 100 Labour Party MPs have called on Sir Keir Starmer to resign as prime minister. Some cabinet ministers, including Shabana Mahmood, the home secretary, have privately urged Sir Keir to go; some junior ministers have quit. Still, on Tuesday he averred that no one had launched a leadership challenge and said he would stay in office.

Few expect [Sir Keir to last much longer](#). But his pledge to plough on makes the process of replacing him messier. If a leadership challenge is triggered and Sir Keir chooses to stand, he will automatically be nominated. Meanwhile, each contender to replace him has flaws. Britain's governing party faces civil war.

Hit the ground

Britain, shortest-serving prime ministers
since 1900, days in office



*Still prime minister at May 12th 2026

Source: HM Government



Photograph: Getty Images

Japan's prodigal Son

Japanese firms may have a reputation for being risk-averse. Masayoshi Son, the founder of SoftBank Group, one of Japan's largest companies, is anything but. By October his [sprawling investment house](#) will have ploughed \$65bn into OpenAI, the artificial-intelligence firm behind ChatGPT. It will also soon pay \$5bn for the robotics arm of ABB, a Swiss engineering firm, and will snap up DigitalBridge, a data-centre business, for \$4bn.

SoftBank's earnings for the financial year ending in March—which it reported on Wednesday—suggest that its AI bets are paying off. Net profit quadrupled to ¥5trn (\$32bn); net sales were up nearly 8% to ¥7.8trn (\$49bn). Investors are enthusiastic. SoftBank's share price has surged lately, helping to lift Japan's benchmark Nikkei 225 index to a record high this week. But the firm's creditors are growing wary of the mounting debt needed to finance Mr Son's spending spree. In March s&p Global lowered its outlook for the group from stable to negative. With so much borrowed cash being funnelled into AI projects, SoftBank cannot afford to stumble.



Photograph: Getty Images

The red carpet and The White Lotus

For the next 11 days, the streets of Cannes will be teeming with Hollywood A-listers and the greats of international cinema. But fewer American movie stars may attend this year's film festival than normal.

Just two American films—"Paper Tiger", a gangster thriller, and "The Man I Love", a musical—are competing for the top prize, the Palm d'Or. Thierry Frémaux, the festival's director, has played down suggestions that American studios are retreating, but said that the decline in the number of blockbusters had made him "nostalgic" for the "golden age" of American cinema. He said problems in the industry, including strikes and the Los Angeles wildfires, had made it harder for Hollywood to "greenlight big films".

Ironically, another part of America's entertainment industry will be highly visible. Scenes from the upcoming series of the television hit ["The White Lotus"](#) are being filmed in Cannes during the festival. At a big-screen event, a small-screen production is generating much of the buzz.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: The departure of which baseball player in 1920 is supposed to have resulted in a long-lasting curse on the Boston Red Sox?

Tuesday: Which American president was born in a town called Hope?

*Art is made to disturb. Science
reassures.*

Georges Braque